NEURODIVERGENT PRIDE

#14

MUTUAL AID

WHAT AUTISTIC MINDS CAN TEACH EACH OTHER AND THE WORLD

INTRODUCTION

Joe Biel

A few weeks ago I received an email from a friend that I hadn't spoken to in 20 years.[1] He was apologizing for what he perceived as transgressions that he had committed against me in 2002. While the apology was very sweet, it wasn't necessary. In fact, I had no recollection or even idea of what the hell he was talking about. Clearly, it had resonated harder for him than myself.

He had written a letter to a magazine that I was a writer for, criticizing gaps and contradictions in an article that I hadn't written or even seen until publication. I wasn't specifically named in the criticisms, but I was implicated in them, I guess. Apparently—and, again, I have no recollection of this—he recalls that his roommate had told him

1 By standard rules of autistic discourse, I hold that you are still friends even after not speaking for 20 years as long as there wasn't a disruption to the friendship as long as both parties are willing to reignite the relationship, as is true here.

that I had commented it was "well written and entirely wrong." While this is absolutely how I talked in 2002, his criticism hadn't affected me. I was a sharply didactic individual at that age, which was only cultivated and honed by the punk rock world that I firmly occupied. It was our obligation to criticize and correct each other. It was so socially expected that if someone was seen as ignoring bad behavior, it was seen as equally transgressive. So perhaps I was playing it safe by being overly critical—and then forgetting about it. I don't honestly remember. Or maybe this was a misunderstanding or never happened. Still, an apology never hurts.

But equally curious, an archivist, and a researcher—I *still have a copy of the magazine*! So I dug it up and reread it. I completely agree with what he said—that criticizing someone for taking money from tylenol to put free independent records in two thirds of independent record stores is no more hypocritical than the very magazine taking ad money from record labels with tendrils reaching into far more nefarious dark corners of capitalism. Chides like this are a fairly tired trope of punk rock. Our "You're leaning too far

into capitalism" is the "Are you really going to eat that?" of diet culture. It's a boring argument because it's an easy one and we *already* feel dirtier and guiltier than our critic realizes. And if you don't, you simply don't care about the barb.

Now, I'm not saying that we shouldn't question each other's motives in our community. I'm saying that critical thinking and the merit of original arguments should receive the most weight. The way that he easily dismantled a smart-sounding but very specious long-form article in six paragraphs is commendable. And more than that, it turns out that my friend was discreetly defending *his friend* who got hired by Tylenol and was clever enough to redirect funds to distribute independent records that I might even enjoy listening to!

It got me thinking. What is the point of community if you aren't willing to stick your neck out for your friends? Community has to be more than criticizing each other. Otherwise, I'd want nothing to do with it. I appreciated his apology, unfounded and out of place as it was. It helped me to see that we actually agree about the issues.

When the same magazine ran an article in defense of widely criticized Deep Elm Records, framed as "investing Wall Street funds to support punk" which I read as "What utter horse shite is this?" I was rather shocked when even my friends fell for this argument. Again, I was a didactic little fucker in those days, unafraid to offend and state my opinion. It was what that culture had nurtured within me. "Think critically, offer that criticism freely no matter who it hurts." It's not always a best practice but it's what I knew.

To the substance of my 2002 criticism of my friend's criticism, I figure that if I ever actually said that it was "entirely wrong," what I actually meant was that it misses the actual crux of the matter. When I interviewed punk rock magnate and DIY purist Ian MacKaye in 1995, he told me "You are only as independent as your distribution." And that resonated to my spine. I was probably feeling a little defensive because I spent 2002 signing an agreement with a book distributor and finding the whole thing deeply underwhelming. I had been indoctrinated that you "have to have a distributor" despite my previous experience running a record label

and watching every distributor be gobbled up and consolidated by a larger one, that failed to improve the level of service for, you know, distributing records. So while Ian was really ten years ahead of his time with that quote, he only become more accurate over time as the industry continued to consolidate.

My distributor experience was awful. So we signed with another, and then another, and once we had completed the tour of all of them, we resumed distributing ourselves. Our sales literally quintupled within a few years. It was painfully hard to miss. We had to triple our staff to keep up. I was bewildered. How could we be better at this than a global corporation?

Simultaneously, back in 2002, I think I was poorly trying to explain to my friend's roommate that the letter was missing that perspective—there's gradations of purity and independence. Nowadays, I'm far less baked into purity culture, embracing the gray areas, and doing what we need to do in order to pay rent for dozens of people. Though I do miss having a magazine where we could intellectually debate which punks are selling out to Tylenol. However, if we

were still distributed by a global corporation we would not be able to effectively distribute books about most topics that are actually interesting to the people who actually care about them because we'd be overwhelmed responding to our distributor's confused questions, being asked to sign pointless contract addendums, and fill out paperwork that none of our books contain Chinese plastic parts. It's not why anyone gets into publishing. I digress.

It's easy to be a critic. And mostly unhelpful. I've brushed elbows and been roommates and friends with dozens of people who went on to become public figures or even featured in the most mainstream outlets. While they no longer have time to reach out with a random apology, they are happy to trade stories when we cross paths. It's one of the positive aspects of being middle aged and growing up in the cutting edge cultural milieu era of Portland, Ore. Unerringly, these are people who draw criticism through various misunderstandings and interpretable expressions. And often those barbs sting deep long after the people dispensing them have long forgotten them. So I've made it my job to

apologize on behalf of my brethren of critics. It's often simple words like "I'm sorry that you're dealing with that. I felt like those criticisms were rather unwarranted." One friend was called "The sexiest woman on television" which horrified me at the time because sexualizing someone in that way is a major punk rock no-no. But she was flattered. She held it up like a proud badge. I mean, thinking it through, I'd like to be the sexiest woman on television too, however fleeting that descriptor probably is.

When a close friend read my memoir, *Good Trouble: Building a Successful Life and Business with Autism*, for the first time, her response was "Wow, I thought your story would be about hanging out with people who went on to be famous but the whole time you were essentially alone and cleaning up messes."

"I *was* basically alone the whole time, cleaning up others' messes, feeling misunderstood and being criticized for it." I responded.

She nodded solemnly.

My experience isn't unique. In fact, it's so common that dozens of other autistic people have written memoirs about being cast aside,

misunderstood, and criticized. I came to realize that the book may have been a misstep; instead of telling my story, my job was to build a movement of people who were aiming to learn from their mistakes to help each other.

Reflecting on this, a few weeks ago a friend publicly criticized an episode of my podcast—interpreting it as a personal attack on her best friend's method of publishing. And you know, it made me realize that I respect that. Defending our friends is what makes everything more than just capitalism. It's what makes the discourse shape us into something more empathic.

These days, I think of mutual aid as thinking critically but holding my tongue to listen. Other people sometimes want my opinion but I find that they ask for it when they do and more importantly—often their perspective and experience can inform mine. There is nothing gained by hurting their feelings just because my take is different from theirs. That's been formative in my autistic quest to build community. I can hold those skills close without assuming that I have the hottest take. Even in cases where I do—

others have lived experiences that can make it even more poignant.

So that's where I'm at now. I've sent dozens of apology letters for things that I've said and done before my diagnosis where the incidents are much clearer to me now and cause me to live with regret. The apologies are usually met with as much confusion as I felt when someone reached out after 20 years to apologize for a letter that I didn't remember. Still, it's not about repairing every misstep so much as it is about the process of transforming ourselves to proceed in a more informed manner moving forward towards mutual aid. I've learned how to better apologize in the moment where it can heal a disconnect and to stop doing something when I'm asked to do so, even if I disagree about the reasons why. Respecting and supporting others is how I think about community these days, rather than feeling like I have to criticize something before someone else criticizes me for not doing so fast enough. As a result, I get to feel understood and supported in turn. Living this way has built relationships in the strangest of places, as we'll see in this issue.

ORGANIZING THE NEURODIVERGENT PORTLAND PUBLIC SCHOOLS STAFF

Andrew Coltrin

In the Fall of 2023, my employer, Portland Public Schools, endured a three week strike by the members of the teachers' union, the Portland Association of Teachers (PAT). I, myself, am in a different union, the Portland Federation of School Professionals (PFSP). PFSP represents much of the classified staff in the district. We're the office administrative assistants, the educational assistants (EAs), the high school bookkeepers, the library assistants, the campus security monitors, and, in my case, the special education paraeducators.

For the most part, my bargaining unit is made up of non-salary, Fair Labor Standards

Act non-exempt, hourly employees. We're not teachers. Our workday is the workday. We have federal and state protections regarding things like meal breaks and overtime.

We also work for an employer that excels at finding loopholes.

During the teacher strike, we faced a lot of uncertainty. First of all, PFSP was also in contract negotiations, but we had not gotten to the mediation stage, and we were barred by Oregon's Public Employee Collective Bargaining Agreement Laws from picketing with the teachers while our union was technically still in negotiations with the District. At the same time, the School District was not legally allowed to lock out employees from non-striking job groups.

The school administrative assistants still went to school every day, catching up on paperwork in the school offices and addressing questions from parents (not that they had answers). They ran out of work about a week into the strike, but they still had to be there every day. The student-centered positions, like EAs and Paras, were in a more confusing position.

The district couldn't avoid paying us for contract workdays, but they also had to scramble to find work for us to do. Some paraeducators were deployed to district-supervised charter schools that remained open because their teachers were not represented by the union. This, of course, is a weird and disorienting proposition. Most of the EAs and Paras, however, were dragooned into doing something the district called "Literacy Coaching."

The Literacy Coaching was something akin to the distance learning strategies applied during the Covid shutdowns of 2020 and 2021. At the time, no one liked it or thought it was very effective. But all the kids have school-issued chromebooks now. The thought was that unlicensed staff with a crash course in an online curriculum could do a fair job doing literacy coaching for selective students, based on an assessment given at the beginning of the school year.

For special education paraeducators—especially the ones who typically work in self-contained classrooms, or with non-verbal students, or students with complicated medical

needs—literacy coaching was way outside our normal scope of operation. Especially considering, during normal school times, we are supposed to be supervised by certified, licensed teachers when delivering curriculum.

What the district was asking us to do with "Literacy Coaching" seemed way too close to acting as the teacher, which is something we're legally and contractually not allowed to do. In fact, paraeducators have been specifically trained not to act as a main point of contact for parents. We can be polite, and friendly, but anything regarding scheduling or plans or curriculum is supposed to be handled by teachers, lest any confusion occur that may lead to embarrassing legal action. However, with the teachers on strike, it was delegated to classified Paras and EAs to contact families to coordinate Literacy Coaching sessions.

I was coincidentally on family leave during most of the strike, so I got to sit on the sidelines. But I did attend PFSP union meetings and stayed in contact with my immediate co-workers to keep in the loop. It was at the very first union meeting

held after the roll-out of the Literacy Coaching plan that something became very clear to me:

A whole lot of attendees at that zoom meeting were showing plenty of neurodivergent traits. And, on top of those traits they were showing signs of the anxiety and the clenched, pent up frustration fed by prior social trauma. We were all stressed out, confused, worried, mistrustful, and angry, and everyone's mask was slipping.

One fellow union member, almost in tears over the confusing change in routine, the anxiety over contacting families directly, and the conflict over delivering educational instruction above and beyond their training, stopped just short of disclosing a diagnosis in the meeting.

I'd theorized for years that being a special education paraeducator is the kind of job that neurodivergent people find their way into. There's a few obvious attractive traits. First, it's a relatively easy job to get. School districts have trouble filling the position. For people who, for various reasons, have trouble formatting their resume or getting through a job interview, there's less competition for the job. Secondly, there are a lot of built in breaks in the school

year. Neurodivergent people tend to need a lot of down time and it can be a little easier to make sure you get it when there's about three months of down time baked into the job. And, most importantly, a lot of us are there because we have a deep personal interest in doing what we can to make school a better place for people like us. That meeting showed me that my theory had some grounds to it.

After the strike was over, there were a lot of big, difficult feelings all around. Some of the classified staff were angry and felt like our job group was treated as a pawn in the drawn out power struggle between the district and the teachers. Talking to my immediate co-workers about how frustrating the experience was, especially for those who had confided their neurodivergence to me, I became more convinced that keeping isolated wasn't doing any of us any good.

Using a communication strategy that I picked up from the teacher's union, I started a chat group on an online messaging platform. I made some connections at my own union's meetings and was able to get the word out there. Several people from different job sites joined the chat group.

We're there for each other, share workplace gripes and jokes, and, most importantly, we let each other know that we're not alone.

Most modern workplaces, especially those in the public and the private sectors, are isolating and toxic environments for neurodivergent people. This is especially true in the public schools. For as much lip service that is given to inclusion and diversity, much more pressure is placed on the values of personal privacy, self-determination and independence. School employees are often not allowed to speak openly about student disabilities, even and especially when we strongly identify with them.[2] This translates to a reluctance to talk about our own disabilities and a systemic pressure to mask harder to preserve the illusion that, in America, everyone is equal if they try hard enough.

This isn't true.

There's a de facto policy of *don't ask, don't tell* when it comes to neurodivergence and invisible disabilities. Even if it's not official, even if there may be specific language in the ADA

2 Ed note: There are strong and undeniable parallels to people who work in recovery, where disclosure is also seen as compromising the situation rather than showing that you can truly relate.

to discourage discrimination against disability, we all know it's there. We also know masking hard wears us down and actually makes it less possible for us to live full lives. At the same time, not masking at all carries the risk of losing our lives, or at least our livelihoods.

Is this really how I want to exist?

No. I refuse to live under that kind of internalized ableism. I did it for years, but I finally broke the masquerade at work during the Covid shutdowns. I came out as autistic with my co-workers and kept building momentum from there. The more I shared about myself, the more meaningful and supporting interactions I was able to have with those around me. Parents of neurodivergent students have connected with me and built relationships outside the limits of the school building. I've become a mentor for students that I've been able to openly discuss autism and neurodivergence with. I was approached by the school counselors about starting a Neurodiversity Affinity Group for students at my school. For the second year in a row this spring, in spite of an overarching district culture that is toxic and rife with unthinkingly

ableist policies, my school was able to observe Neurodiversity Celebration Week.

Neurodiversity Celebration Week was started in the UK by autistic ADHDer, Siena Castellon, in 2018 when she was a student. Neurodiversity Celebration Week changes how neurodivergence is perceived and talked about in schools and institutions. When my school was going to participate, I got involved to make sure it didn't just become a week of inspiration porn. As an ND person successfully participating in an NT dominated world, I've seen students in the past two years, go from withdrawn, guarded, and defensive to open and connecting with peers. I've seen classmates become allies. Teachers and staff open up about themselves, sharing their experiences with students, creating a more understanding and compassionate environment.

The more that I've been open about myself, sharing my experience and my curiosity about neurodiversity, the more people around me feel comfortable and empowered to do the same. It was time I took a step beyond my worksite and encouraged other ND people in the district to connect.

I knew that there were more scattered neurodivergent staff members out there, and I found them. Not all of them are ready to disclose, and I absolutely respect that. Some of them, lacking a formal diagnosis, are a little stuck in some feelings of imposter syndrome. They know that they are experiencing difficulties but haven't connected the dots yet; which is a lonely and confusing place to occupy during the best of times—let alone during a teacher's strike. But all of them have thanked me for creating a platform for this little group, where we can feel heard and seen after a long day at a workplace where we often feel beaten down and disregarded.

It might not be the grandest and most impactful form of mutual aid, but it's a start. If nothing else, I hope to show people that when we neurodivergent people reach out and connect with each other, we really do benefit. We share strategies. We lift each other up. We get it. We get how hard it is every day. And we don't have to be patronizing about it. And, hopefully, by showing that it's possible to find allies in greater and greater circles just by being brave enough to share about ourselves.

DEI TRAINING: A TALE OF TWO BOARDS

Joe Biel

In 2024, a friend called. She had just delivered an award to me in a crappy distant suburb of Phoenix while I teared up and nervously answered her questions. This time she was nervous.

"I'm not asking you to do another thing, but I am asking you to do another thing." she meekly mumbled. She clearly expected to be shot down.

"I'll do anything for you." I told her plainly, as I say to my friends who don't test or take advantage of that privilege.

"Well, I want you to participate on an inter-agency industry advisory committee for the publishing industry."

"Of course I'll do it." I responded. I was honestly flattered. In her mind, I was important and overcommitted. The former is subjective and the latter is true, but things like this are educational and rewarding.

Besides, I had somehow found myself as the Vice President of another advocacy organization rather unexpectedly. I was excited but it was mostly a baby kissing position. I wasn't doing the work that I had signed up for. Each time that I tried to make changes or had ideas on how to improve our effectiveness, I was told why my ideas didn't work. Things escalated to rejecting ideas out of hand on account of them being "Joe's ideas." When I offered and proposed educational programming for our membership, I was ignored. I felt undermined at every turn. I didn't yet understand that board work can be about serving a few people's egos. And thus they feel threatened when the ideas come from elsewhere.

At a trade show in Cincinnati, I sat down with a fellow board member, trying to figure out why the whole experience had felt like a bewildering tail spin for the past few years. We made a list of people that we felt were being obstructive to change. The list was exceptionally short. In fact, we failed to come up with a second name.

"Could one person really be preventing progress and change within the organization?" she yelled out of exasperated frustration.

We both had to think about that one for a few minutes before someone familiar with the situation walked up and confirmed that this was exactly what was going on.

Sure enough, during our next meeting, the obstructionist drew out a fantastical narrative of fear about how any and every change would quickly spell the end of the organization. We had to follow her plan and her plan alone—which was to change nothing at all and to remove anyone from the organization that she felt threatened by—including me and another member.

I dealt with this by having private phone calls with every board member. I asked them if they approved of removing members and each one expressed how uncomfortable they felt about this but had been told it was the only way forward. I intervened and preserved the integrity of the organization's board. Still, I was confused why we weren't working together on the organization's actual mission and deliverables.

Six months later, that same obstructionist relayed an exaggerated rumor about me to someone that I worked with on the industry advisory committee. I was bewildered. Was she

attempting to sow discontent or merely an awful strategist? Which is worse? *Why wouldn't she talk to me before distributing rumors that make both of our lives more difficult?* Should I make the board aware that she compiled a secret complaint document titled "Board Investigation?"

And that's when it clicked. Someone willing to sit down with me and have a meta conversation to resolve a conflict believes in mutual aid. Someone sowing discontent and creating backchannel obstructions fears it.

The other person that the obstructionist had attempted to drive out and I formed a friendship. It was an unlikely one. Was the bond of our relationship that we are both difficult to work with? Perhaps. But she became deeply supportive of me. She offered to interpret the mood, tone, and facial expressions of meetings for me. I offered to help her work on strategy—when to stay quiet and when and how to speak up about addressing concerns and ideas. She trusted me with her feelings, secrets, worries, and how she didn't like being treated. We were a team—of people united by someone's dislike of us.

Quickly, I made more close friends on the board. We were united by the bumpy ride of trying to figure out "What the hell just happened?" We realized that we had a lot in common but had been kept apart by the structure of the organization.

Around the same time, my involvement on the industry advisory committee picked up. I attended monthly meetings and saw how the other organization functioned. Everyone's time was respected. We were focused on the targets and centralized the mission. The organization had a scarred reputation because of their former CEO, who had redirected them to make money from the boom of self-publishing in 2012. This had earned a negative mark in my mind. So I was surprised to find that this organization felt much closer to my values and priorities. I was selected as a keynote for their conference that Spring, and they did not balk when I told them that I needed a support person to help me feel comfortable in an unfamiliar environment, but we could do this within their budget.

That conference remains one of my best experiences in 30 years of publishing. It was full of fellow innovative people who had been

cast out of the mainstream. They had been building up ideas in these corners for years and envisioning a few to get their foot in the door while others were insistent upon slamming it. As I came down the escalator to the show floor for the first time, people asked if they could take photos with me and ask me questions. I had never been surrounded by so many people who had read my book, *A People's Guide to Publishing*, and were quoting it back to me. These people were both my fans and my peers. I realized that I had previously gotten involved with the wrong organization because of my own biases.

Now, I reserve compliments for when they are truly earned and deserved. But the leadership and membership of this organization are truly inspiring. They were everything that I had been looking for over the past 30 years.

Still, my heart sank and I was filled with dread when they told me that I would have to attend six hours of Diversity Equity and Inclusion (DEI) training to work on the industry advisory committee. I mean, I think DEI training is important but at the same time, I feel that I have learned those lessons from the various

ways that I have been cast out, mistreated, misjudged, and discriminated against my whole life. I complained to close friends, likely for more than six hours, thinking about how agonizing these meetings would be.

Nonetheless, I showed up on day one, with a bowl of beans and a cup of iced tea packed. I was open and prepared to listen. So I was surprised when the presenter was engaging and interesting. He was a Black man with a background in engineering who lives in rural Pennsylvania. He told a story of sitting with a blind man at a cafeteria dinner. He repeatedly tried to help the blind man and was repeatedly dismissed. Finally, the blind man asked him if he needed anything, as he was heading back to the salad bar. Sure enough, the blind man returned with the requested items as well as his own. Turns out he's been taking care of his own needs for most of his life.

I enjoyed this as a story of mutual aid, but I was mostly amused by this as a method of showing off from the high road. When someone else is underestimating your capabilities—a situation that I'm entirely accustomed to—there's

a time and a place to show off. Still, I figured that this is probably how I usually come across and perhaps why I rub some people wrong—even when I'm correct, I'm still grating because I'm not always hearing their subtext.

I recall the time when I was invited to be a guest on a podcast as the token autistic and the producer insisted on explaining time zones to me—that it would be early for me and how I might be tired. Annoyed, I listened to a few episodes to prepare and found that they always asked the same questions, so I prepared my answers. Yet when the day came, they treated me like a child and suggested that my contributions to the audience were that of seeing me as lesser than. Then, to my horror, when the episode was released, it came with an awful disclaimer that they weren't expecting me to be as capable of answering questions or functioning to the same level as their other guests and that my ability to cope should not be interpreted as being representative of autistic people. There's a certain saying in autistic circles "If you've met one autistic person, then you've met one autistic person" which is our way of saying "Neurotypical

people have a disability that prevents them from seeing the commonalities that unite autistic people because they focus on the wrong things, such as what is different about each of us."

When the DEI training broke into groups, it became clear to me why it was necessary. One person asked the moderator if, as a Black person, cultural appropriation was okay or not.[3] Another expressed that she didn't like having a client point out repeatedly that white people had always taken advantage of him. After several fellow white women comforted her and suggested "he is working on it, at least," I suggested "Can you hear what his experience is; how you have more power in the relationship?" And while this caught her off guard, to her credit she responded "Yes, I can see that. Thank you for pointing that out." I was somewhat confused because she had made herself out to be the harmed party in this scenario, but was able to shift her thinking.

---

3 I feel like this question is strange because it's not a didactic issue so much as it's one of each person's individual values and priorities. Do you want to offend some people by coopting their culture for your own benefit? Does that conform to your value system?

I told the story of how riding the bus to work every morning, upon seeing me, the drivers always lowered the ramp to the curb, as if I couldn't take one step up. I wasn't sure if this was supportive or infantilizing. So I posed my question to the group. Everyone grew very uncomfortable. I realized that they were not living with similar conditions and thus didn't feel qualified to offer an opinion. I can respect that. I told them that the driver sometimes greeted me with baby talk and the same thing happens at the hospital. One driver, in an effort to be supportive, would offer me a daily compliment about one aspect of my appearance.

"Those are great shoes" he would say, beaming at my pink velcro kicks.

They are great shoes so I didn't think much of it the first time. But as I wore t-shirts with cartoon characters or goofy puns on them and he focused on the most childish parts of my appearance, the compliments turned up daily. I realized that there was more afoot. As this shifted into their comprehension, that this was a daily occurrence of how I live my life the group looked shocked and offered "I'm sorry that this happens

to you" which honestly means a lot to have that be affirmed.

Still, I preferred the bus drivers' behavior to the way other passengers made fun of feminine aspects of my appearance or my purse, sometimes going as far as bordering on hate speech. Now, I'm not terribly sensitive or feeling unsafe, but both of these extremes feel unhelpful to me. Or as my neurodivergent coworker put it as I arrived at work one day "They either treat you like a baby or they call the police." And he's right. Where is the nuance? This is exactly what had irked me for my entire life. I was either a threat or needing protection. Others' perception of me is not as someone with agency who has opinions and contributions of value.

These events happened in my mid to late 40s. I'm comfortable with who I am. I don't think I'm entitled to any special treatment or heraldry. I do, however, think that the ideas with the most merit should get the most attention—whether those are mine or someone else's. And that's what DEI training really taught me. Mutual aid comes in the form of actually hearing each other and taking concerns seriously rather than

obfuscating or misinterpreting. That's where feeling supported comes from as well. And if these are my experiences, I can only assume that the reason that so many Black publishers within this organization relate to me is because I speak to their experience of being ignored as well. It was surprising to find so many publishers that I felt kinship with in one place, but it's moments like that which makes decades of being treated like I don't understand time zones worthwhile. The friend who invited me on the committee constantly tells me how smart I am. So one day I told her that we are intellectual equals. She thought I was being polite and blushed. I pushed back. "No, you are the closest thing to a peer that I have after 30 years." She was able to hear that one but I find that people who have trouble accepting compliments need them the most. So keep them coming.

So here's one more for my friend: It's amazing what baking mutual aid protocols into an organization can do to make me feel safe and accepted.

RAISING CHILDREN WITH HIGH DEF AUTISM
(or AuDies Raising AuDies)

Theresa Pizza

Before any parenting work can begin you have to like your child/ren. I don't give a tinker's damn if your kid is the most annoying pile of noise with dirt attached. YOU HAVE TO LIKE THEM. You have to like spending time with them.

Notice it's *like,* not love. Yes, I'm sure you love them, or you wouldn't be reading this. If you don't want to spend time with your child one-on-one and you do not look forward to doing so, you have to work on that. Okay, how? You have to spend a lot of time with them.

Try structured activities first—park, library, sibling's sport event or whatever you do. It doesn't have to be big, long, expensive or anything. It only has to be a place or activity where you and the child you're not too jazzed about can spend time

alone together. Make the first time short. You can go slow but I urge you to keep in mind the fact that children do not stay children forever.

When they are small it feels like you will be their maid for the rest of your life. Eventually things slowly shift and change. Sadly, the thing that works for changing a relationship with a kid you're not feeling jazzed by is to spend time with them *consistently*.

Don't worry if there isn't much talking, at first that's probably better. Just be. No nagging, no nitpicking, no baloney small talk. Just walk (or roll or sit) together and be together in companionable silence. Spend as much time with your child as you can so you can grow and learn from each other. Do it because you love your child. Do it because you want a better life for your family, do it because it is the right thing to do.

Since the original ABA therapy is a hot mess of authoritarian Soviet torture involving screaming at three-year-olds for stimming and—in the bad old days—smacking them for self-injurious behavior. The originator of this therapy did not want to find out why these children were injuring themselves or engaging in repetitive

behaviors. *That* is an Autistic feature—to find out why and try to fix it and gain understanding you can then pass on to others.

If an Autistic person came up with a therapy for Autistics, *understanding* would be the core concept. As a parent—this is your core concept for being able to meet your child's needs—for any kid really. Your child must absolutely understand that you are on their side, on their team and are *for* them not against them.

Traditional ABA involves negative reinforcement. Instead, change that to positive reinforcement while making sure you're not dipping too far into overprotective, coddling territory. Judge what your child and your uniqueness deem necessary. You don't have to slip your kid a candy every time they talk instead of shrieking indoors. It can be as simple as saying "Thank you for using a quieter voice inside, that makes it easy for me to understand what you're saying." That's a positive reinforcement but it's not like giving a dog a treat or a horse a peppermint. You're treating them as a human, a sentient human. That is one of those things I think I don't need to say, but I feel better when

I am completely clear and there is less room for misinterpretation.

Treating your child as a sentient human is an absolute must. No matter how nonverbal, or uncommunicative your child is—they are sentient! They hear you, they know you are there! Even if they can't respond yet in a way you understand, always treat them with respect and dignity—as much as you possibly can. Dignity can be hard to come by when you're helping an older child wipe their butt after soiling, believe me, I know that. All I ask and all we as human beings can ever ask for is that parents do their best with what they have. We all know that sometimes, that ain't much.

Many years ago, I found a book called *A Burst of Light* by Audre Lorde at my library. Lorde wrote this book while undergoing treatment for breast cancer, and a lot of it has to do with caring for yourself. It is the best book about self-care I have ever read. From this book I learned the cold hard fact that: *you need to care for yourself* so you can care for your child/ren. But don't take my word for it. It's a slim volume and a lesbian/mother/warrior/poet can put it a lot better than I can!

You must have time that is your own—every day, if possible. I don't give two shits if it's fifteen minutes before everyone wakes up around 5 am or ten minutes to yourself after everyone is in bed before you go to sleep. If you are Autistic this time should be spent in solitude. Also note, these are bare minimums that I would have needed when I was living in toddler and preschooler land. For you? This is a starting point, your needs may be more, significantly more, or less. You know yourself. (I hope! Or you're getting to know yourself!) This time is *not optional*. You need time alone to mentally process all the interactions, to breathe, and to not have to do anything for someone else.

Real talk: you either take care of yourself now or risk a nervous breakdown and/or burnout in the future. You cannot be there for your child, guide them through therapy and medical care as well as attend to the needs of anyone else (other children, partner, pets) if your needs are not taken care of. The child/ren aren't going to say, "Gee you look tired parental unit. Why don't you take a load off and I'll get my own snack and drink." {Remember in *Hitchhiker's Guide to the Galaxy*

where there was a flashing red banner above the scene with humans and monkeys having dinner together? "This never happens!"}

Make sure that you put on sunblock, and you carry snacks for yourself, too. Bring a full water bottle for yourself, not just theirs. Plan things that you like and that interest all of you (or could possibly interest you). Actively attempt to not be tied to a certain outcome. A trip to the beach may be just the thing or a total disaster. If you are well rested, not in pain, and not hungry, thirsty or have to pee, you'll be able to deal with it easily and laugh off any whoopsies (for those in the UK I mean a mistake, not a poop.) Take your relaxation where you can, especially if resources are low (cash, helpful friends and family.)

ABA has changed a lot since it's inception. Some agencies still push the 40 hours a week of therapy and doing "Drills" (a person repeats what they want you to do until you do it, "touch the red stop sign in the picture" they'll say and then they just keep repeating "touch red, touch red" until you do or you kill them, whatevs) Obviously you avoid these companies like they are radioactive.

I consider the adaptations that we use to have more in common with the RDI program for Autism therapy than ABA and certainly it looks nothing like the traditional 40 hour week of drills. RDI is parent-based and no therapists come to the house. The facilitator trains you as the parent to create positive therapeutic activities with your child.

You are now screwing with the system. You're taking the ABA Therapy that your insurance will pay for and turning it into something that will benefit your child. You are looking through the companies that your insurance covers and you are going to go through them and find one with therapists that have schooling and experience and are Neurodiversity Affirming. They may not come out and say that they are, but you'll be able to extrapolate that information once you interact with them.

As soon as you meet a therapist, you'll see how they work and together you'll work out your child's goals. When your child is old enough—they pick their own goals (at first with some assistance, then completely on their own.) The therapist's job is to work out a plan to meet those

goals that works for your child and you in your day-to-day lives. Therapists break goals down into steps and you start small.

As your child is able to get closer to the goal, you celebrate every milestone. This shows your child that they are capable and shows you that they are capable. Guess who else is capable? YOU! Because you helped your child do it!

This is not the method for folks who want the therapist to do everything. You are gonna be very involved at first, especially if your child is small and/or not talking, because *you* know your child. The therapist knows procedures to facilitate but they need to see how you and your child interact. This way the therapist can adapt their style of communication to the one you both already use. You'll have to be involved and there for the sessions, every time unless you're at work (or something equally important, natch—I don't know your life) to facilitate communication and to have the therapist show you how to reinforce what is going on during the session in the home on a regular basis.

I know that sounds like a whole lot of work. It sure as hell can be especially if you are working

at all as well as raising children with High Def Autism and having it, too. The intensity will not be forever (even though it seems like it) but it will likely be years before you start to notice tangible benefits *for you*. Your child, family unit, and all of you together will have lots of improvements early on. The tangible benefits I refer to are less therapy and your involvement slowly pulling away as your child develops their communication skills and starts to work with the therapist directly.

Most of all, *be nice*! Please be nice to yourself and your child. Give yourselves grace and forgiveness for not being the best or always making the right choice. In fact, sometimes you will make all the right choices and still lose. As Captain Picard said, "That is not failure, that is life."

Honestly when this started happening, I felt strange about it. I stood around in the kitchen while my kid and his therapist worked in the living room. I felt like I was cheating on something! They didn't need me at all. I could go read my book or diddle on my phone or something. It was a shock!

Some days will run like a well-oiled machine and some days will be total and complete shit. You have to grab your thrills (fun and relaxation) where you can and when you can. Yes, obviously, the child/ren take precedence over little luxuries or some of the things you want but don't need. However, your *actual needs* (food, shelter, clothing, temperature regulation, water, medical attention, rest) come first. Control the variables you can so that the variables you can't control don't overwhelm you.

Treat your failures as opportunities to learn and you'll always improve. One of Shmuz's favorite sayings at age eight was "I just did my own best!" Do your own best and you'll be rewarded in ways that are difficult to conceptualize but fantastic to experience.

PERSPECTIVE IS EVERYTHING

Joe Biel

I always reread the previous issues of *Neurodivergent Pride* when I'm putting together a new one and I am often shocked to discover things that I wrote three to five years ago. It's not that I disagree with my former self so much as I am shocked that the world kept on turning after I made a public proclamation that felt personally Earth-shattering and even humiliating in hindsight. Writing in print is powerful because you're sending a targeted message to a safe group that you trust.

I don't regret being forthcoming with my personal life. I feel like this is the purpose of this exercise: to make readers feel less alone in a lonely world as they get up the gumption to survive past 36—the point where suicide is the most likely end of autistic lives. It's a bold goal, but it's the one that I choose repeatedly since this

publication was envisioned on a train platform in London in 2017.

Eighteen years ago I was in a relationship where I felt wholly unsupported. I was treated like the adult in the relationship because I was a few years older and thus expected to have all the answers. My partner at the time was a social worker in after school programs. When I began to realize that I was autistic and this is why I was missing so many social cues that were obvious to them, it was similar to each time that I talked to an adult who had worked with autistic children. I was told dismissive things like "Joe, I work with autistic kids. They cannot tell when you are joking."

Detecting an opening, I responded *"I can't tell when someone is joking."*

Only to be met with "That's true but . . . It's not the same."

"How is it not the same?" I pushed back.

And summarily each instance of me successfully masking or coping is held up as "proof" that I am not autistic after all.

Even after experts, doctors, therapists, and fellow autistic people all confirmed that I am, in fact, autistic, this perspective shift cannot sink into people who knew me before my diagnosis. And so many of them had to be slowly reduced to the margins of my relationships lest it become a routine argument.

But there's hope. My friend who delivered me with the award and struggled to accept that she's my intellectual equal called me one day. "Can I ask you a question? You say that you are autistic, but I cannot see it. . . No, I'm sorry. That's wrong. I cannot ask that." she stammered.

"It's okay." I said, savoring the opportunity to correct the official record of neurotypical interpretation of our species. "What you experience is a product of a certain amount of effort and lifelong education on my part. Autistic people have to try harder in order to be accepted. Otherwise, we tend to be seen as selfish assholes. I care about other people's experiences and don't want to risk that interpretation, so I try harder."

She had relatives that worked with autistic children so she had a harder time understanding how they would grow into something resembling

me. I did my best to walk someone through how and when I grew up informed my ability to learn from my mistakes until I had stumbled into something that could pass for functionality. I found people that take care of and look out for me—but didn't overstep these roles to the detriment of taking care of themselves. She is one of these people, whether she recognizes this or not.

In many cases, these opportunities result in the same people reaching out to me whenever they need guidance on how to better love the autistic people in their lives. My best friend's cousin is autistic and copes with her life by avoiding her family. The boomer parents are overbearing and unwilling to hear others' perspectives, so the kids variously cope with this by making fun of their parents or lashing out in response. The autistic cousin does this by withdrawing into a loving relationship outside of her family—similar to my own strategy.

So my best friend asked me how to support her cousin. I explained "Do you know how it's hard for you when your mom won't hear you? Well, it's doubly hard for your cousin because

there's a lot more going on in those interactions. Boomers have a tendency to subconsciously conform your cousin to their neurology and behavior. She's overwhelmed so she withdraws."

"Like what?" she asks, both of us savoring this opportunity for learning.

"You know how every question could be interpreted a few different ways and you figure out what the other person means by the context? Well, your cousin cannot read that subtext. She's trapped by the syntax of what is being said; trying to oblige that request. So when your mom tries to get her to agree with her but she doesn't agree . . . that's just anxiety producing for her because she can tell it's a trap but doesn't have an opportunity to respond in earnest."

We bond because my analysis is even more on the nose than I realized it would be. Just like when I ask her to interpret situations in my life that are confusing and she obliges; it's truly mutual.

I watched a goofy video the other day that purported to know the difference between a close friend and a best friend. I was skeptical and excited to poke holes in it. Nonetheless, I

continued. It said "A close friend knows all of your stories. A best friend helped you write them."

And holy shit. Not only do I agree with this assessment, but my best friend is *actually* my best friend. We untangle each other's experiences into writing those stories that contain us. And I cannot think of a greater gift between two friends besides making sense of nonsense.

CONTRIBUTORS

Joe Biel is a self-made #ActuallyAutistic publisher, winner of the PubWest Innovator Award in 2024 and founder and CEO of *Publishers Weekly's* fastest growing publisher, 2022-2024. Joe draws origins, inspiration, and methods from punk rock. Joe is the founder/manager of Microcosm Publishing and co-founder of the Portland Zine Symposium. Biel is the author of dozens of books, including *Autism Partner Handbook* and *Good Trouble: Building a Successful Life & Business with Autism*. The *Journal of Adolescent & Adult Literacy* described Biel as "not trained in pedagogy."

Eliot Daughtry is half of killer banshee, a multifaceted collaborative effort with Kriss De Jong dedicated to making and supporting queer art, music and literature. His visual work has been shown internationally, and has received support from the National Endowment for the Arts and the Andy Warhol Foundation. Kriss and Eliot have toured extensively, performing a combination of music and live video manipulation often called expanded cinema. The killer banshee studio has recorded and produced artists including Deep Dickollective and Tribe 8. He illustration the inside and back covers eliot@killerbanshee.com

Theresa Pizza lives in New Jersey with her children Doodlebug and Shmuz and her partner Moonie and their cats Pita and Hummus. Shmuz was diagnosed with ASD and ADHD at age 3, Theresa was diagnosed at age 44 with ASD and ADHD. They have a LOT of special interests!

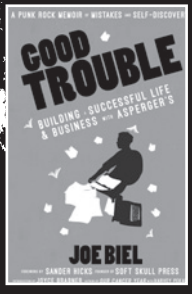
Partly Robot is the alter ego of Andrew Coltrin. Andrew stumbled onto his autism diagnosis after he stopped working in used bookstores and started working in schools. After burning out on being an English teacher, he's been an undercover angel working in the special ed programs of schools in Arizona and Oregon. He also writes odd things and periodically posts on his website PartlyRobot.com.

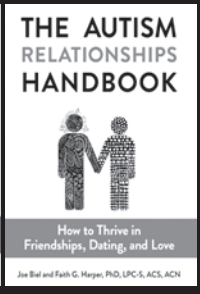
SUBMIT

If you're neurodiverse or an ally, you can submit to the next issue of ***Neurodivergent Pride***, which has the theme of ***Creativity.*** The deadline is ***January 1, 2025***. The following issue's theme is ***Emotions*** and the deadline is ***July 1, 2025.*** The issue after that is ***Controversies*** and the deadline is ***January 1, 2026.*** Submissions should be 500-2,000 words or art.

If ***you are neurodivergent,*** you should submit ***500-2,000 words*** exploring any aspect of the theme.

MORE SELF-DETERMINATION AT WWW.MICROCOSM.PUB

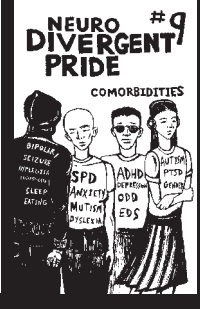


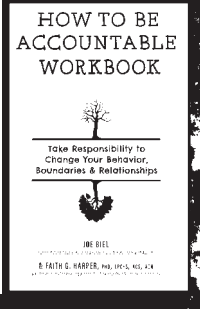


SUBSCRIBE!

For as little as $15/month, you can support a small, independent publisher and get every book that we publish—delivered to your doorstep!

WWW.MICROCOSM.PUB/BFF





Unite and submit: Microcosm.Pub/CFSAutismzine

SKILLS TO CHANGE YOUR LIFE AND THE WORLD

www.Microcosm.Pub

2618 N WILLIAMS AVE • PORTLAND, OR 97227

$6.99 U.S. / $9.99 CANADA

ISBN 978-1-64841-313-1

US$6.99

50699>

9 781648 413131